Pre-History of India

Modern-day India, Nepal and Pakistan have been inhabited by early humans for over 250,000 years according to archaeologists. They include Homo Heidelbergensis, which is a predecessor of contemporary Homo sapiens. Homo Heidelbergensis had been present in the Indian sub-continent long before the Homo Sapiens travelled to the European continent. While archaeologists concentrated on excavations of these early humans within Europe and the Middle East, India was overlooked until the early 20th century. Scholars have been aware of the ancient culture of Harappa since the mid-19th century but did not realize the significance of the site. Instead, they concentrated on finding the locations of areas mentioned in the Mahabharata and the Ramayana, which are known to be written in the fifth or fourth centuries BCE. They discounted the chance of finding sites that predate these periods because they did not think they would find anything significant. When they finally found these sites, archaeologists did not begin working on them until late in the 20th century. A key historical site was found at Balathal, which dates to around 4,000 BCE.

In the last five decades, archaeologists have worked on these new sites and increased our understanding of early Indian history. At Balathal, archaeologists discovered a 4,000 year old skeleton in 2009. The individual is believed to have suffered from leprosy, which is the earliest example in the country. Before the skeleton was unearthed, scholars believed that such a disease originated later on in history. It was believed to have originated in Africa and then transferred to the sub-continent by armies of Alexander the Great in 323 BCE. Excavations have shown that humans became more active in India during the Holocene Era (around 10,000 years ago). This means that our information on the region needs to be reconsidered. Most of what we know has come from Egypt and the Ancient Middle East, known as Asia Minor. It has long been assumed that the Vedic customs emerged after the Aryan migration to India around 1,500 BCE. Instead, it seems likely that they originated from natives who settled at sites such as the Balathal in Ancient India.